

## Agents of TRANSITION

**MALLIKA SHERAWAT** Created a flutter across the country by kissing her co-star 17 times onscreen in one movie. Though her film career failed to kick off, she became the symbol of the sexually liberated woman.



**VIKRAM SETH** He became the poster boy of India's gay rights movement, after being written about in his mother Leila Seth's memoirs. He has been increasingly involved in the fight against

Section 377, garnering support from other heavyweights such as Amartya Sen.



**SHAKEELA AND ROSE** The Malayalam soft-porn actress, Shakeela, outperformed heavyweights such as Mohanlal and Mammooty in Malayalam movie box-office earnings in 2001. Never having appeared frontally nude in any of her films, she considers her nine-inch cleavage to be her greatest asset. India's first transgender talk show *Ippadikku Rose* (Yours Rose) on Star Vijay hosted by Rose Venkatesan is a symbol of changing times.



**THE INTERNET** What cable tv did to us in the 1990s, Internet did for the cause of sexual liberation in the next decade as indigenous pornographic content on the Net grew enormously.

### SPIN-OFFS

## Viewer's Paradise

**Desibaba** Mired in controversy, the first Indian porn site closed down in 2005. But even though Desibaba is dead, long live Desibaba, as spin-offs of the original continue to come up every day. Try Desipapa instead.

**Item girls/Item numbers** They really didn't do much for sexual liberation, but no one complained as they made for great viewing and controversies. At least they were now kissing on the silver screen.

**Savita Bhabhi** The Internet's darling in India, this cartoon character of a bored housewife is the ultimate in graphic raunch. Despite a government ban, the voluptuous bhabhi is back with a new web address.

**MMS Mania** From the now infamous Delhi Public School student's sexually explicit video to Kareena Kapoor kissing Shahid Kapoor, MMS clips became a new-found obsession with Indian youngsters.

body ideal and femininity for contemporary women. The icon of the beauty industry, her image is widely circulated in beauty parlours, which have mushroomed in cities and towns. When her slim back was flaunted on *Kurbaan* posters, the moral police went hoarse protesting against the vulgarity, but not on the grounds that it misrepresented the character she played in the film—a woman academic.

The flip side of this 'sexual revolution' is the freedom to sexualise women's bodies to promote sales. But then, how else does one design an alluring poster that has to compete with hundreds of eye-catching hoardings in the cityscape than by zeroing in on the bare expanse of a woman's back? The country's per capita income may be rising steadily, and enrollment of girls in primary education may also improve with women's increasing presence in the IITs and IIMS, but in a city like Delhi, it is the crime rate against women, the rape of minors in moving cars and harassment of women students in college campuses that continues unabated. One would imagine that India's sexual revolution has come of age with the revocation of Section 377, which has decriminalised homosexuality and reflects increasing maturity in the State's understanding of its citizens. The treatment meted out to my colleague, Professor Shivaji Panikkar, for the role he played as dean in a university in protecting a student,

Srilamanthula Chandramohan, when the latter's paintings were found morally objectionable by right-wing activists, is truly appalling. Still under suspension, Professor Panikkar continues his tirade against the establishment with his 'queer' hat on. That his voice as a queer activist is being increasingly heard in the media, as he critiques the duplicity of heterosexual morality, is reassuring and holds a ray of hope for a more liberal society.

However, the opposition between tradition and modernity on the matter of sexuality refuses to be resolved, driving a wedge between practice and theory. Despite the progressive steps taken by radical activists to demand civic rights for people with alternative sexuality, the discourse continues to be

unresolved. While the experience of the subaltern masses is partially expressed by angry graffiti on the inner recesses of public spaces such as ISBT terminals, the awkward strokes and broken sentences of this graffiti actually thrive outside the circuit of current discourses on sexuality.

unable to encompass the wide practice that is largely determined by the class and caste factor. While the experience of the subaltern masses is partially expressed by angry graffiti on the inner recesses of public spaces such as ISBT terminals, the awkward strokes and broken sentences of this graffiti actually thrive outside the circuit of current discourses on sexuality.

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SEX IS A  
NATURAL  
desire; when  
suppressed, it  
leads to other  
forms of  
expression.

ANJALI  
CHHABRIA  
PSYCHIATRIST